



Cambridge (CIE) IGCSE English Language



Your notes

Question 2: Language Task

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How to Answer Question 2: Language Task

How to Answer Question 2: Language Task

Paper 1: Reading is the compulsory exam in the CIE IGCSE, and CIE examiners recommend that you complete the questions in the order they are set. Question 2 is split into two tasks: a short-answer task and a language analysis task. Both tasks will be based on **Text C** in your reading insert.

The following guide will provide you with the information you need to answer **Question 2: Language analysis task** to a high standard.

Overview

For this task, you will be asked to re-read certain paragraphs from Text C, and explain how the writer uses language to convey meaning and to create effects in these paragraphs. You are instructed to choose **three** examples of words or phrases from **each** paragraph to support your answer, and your choices should include the use of **imagery**.

You are advised to write between 200 and 300 words in your answer; this means about one side of A4 in standard handwriting. Up to 15 marks is available for this question, and you are being tested on the following assessment objectives:

- **R1:** demonstrate understanding of explicit meanings
- **R2:** demonstrate understanding of implicit meanings and attitudes
- **R4:** demonstrate understanding of how writers achieve effects and influence readers

This means, in order to get the highest marks, you need to demonstrate:

- Your ability to select language to analyse appropriately
- Your ability to explore the meanings of the language you have chosen, and why the writer may have chosen them
- Your ability to comment on the use of imagery with precision and imagination
- That you understand how language works

Breaking down the question

Question 2(d) will give you quite detailed instructions. It is therefore important that you read the question carefully and highlight:

- Which paragraphs you need to re-read
- The command words in the question (what you have to do)

- The focus of each question (what you are looking for in the text)
- For example (taken from the June 2022 exam paper):



(d) Re-read paragraphs 10 and 12.

- Paragraph 10 begins 'Because it's there ...' and is about the writer's reactions to other people's views.
- Paragraph 12 begins 'Having said all that ...' and is about the writer's feelings at the end of the race.

Explain how the writer uses language to convey meaning and to create effect in these paragraphs. Choose **three** examples of words or phrases from **each** paragraph to support your answer. Your choices should include the use of imagery.

Write about 200 to 300 words.

Up to 15 marks are available for the content of your answer.

Highlight which paragraphs you need to re-read

This tells you what you have to do

Highlight these instructions and make sure you choose three examples from **each** paragraph

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Steps to success

Following these steps will give you a strategy for answering this question effectively:

1. Read the question and **highlight**:

- The command words (what you are instructed to do)
- The focus of the question (the words or phrases you have to look for in the text)
- The paragraphs you need to re-read

2. Scan the relevant paragraphs in Text C and highlight three examples of language or imagery in each paragraph:

- Keep your annotations short and concise – there is no benefit to highlighting lines and lines of text

3. Write your answer dealing with one paragraph first, and then the other:

- Start with an overview of the paragraph:



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- For example: “In paragraph 10, the writer conveys a feeling of being fiercely protective and a sense of pride in her husband’s choice.”
- Then, select three specific words or phrases to analyse:
 - These selections could include interesting elements of grammar and punctuation
 - Ensure you choose a range of quotations to demonstrate your understanding of how language works
- Do the same for the second paragraph

You are advised to spend no more than 20 minutes on this question (including reading time).

Exam tips

- Read the command words and the paragraph references in the instructions carefully
- Successful answers often start by explaining the literal meaning of the chosen word or phrase in context, and then move on to consider the connotations and impacts caused by the writer’s language choices
- Avoid selecting long quotations or writing generalised comments:
 - Make sure that the quotations you select are precise and accurate
 - Do not copy out lines or chunks of text, or miss out key words
- Remember that you need to choose six words or phrases in total (three from each paragraph):
 - Select words or phrases that you are best able to explain, rather than the ones using the most obvious literary devices
 - Ensure you divide your time equally between both paragraphs
- When explaining how language works, avoid comments such as: “the writer helps us to imagine the scene”. This type of comment is not awarded any marks
- Ensure you also select and explain images created by the writer:
 - Consider the connotations and associations of your chosen words to help you suggest the effect the writer might have wanted to create
 - Successful candidates are able to visualise images and explain their precise meanings
- Importantly, do not simply list literary devices:
 - It is the quality of your analysis that attracts marks, not whether you can spot a metaphor or juxtaposition

The full June 2022 exam paper is available [here](#).

For more advice on how to apply the skills required for success in this question, please see our [Question 2 skills: Language analysis](#) revision notes. For a model answer to this question, please see [Question 2 language task: Model answer](#).



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Question 2 Skills: Language Analysis

Question 2 Skills: Language Analysis

Question 2(d) tests you on your ability to explore, comment on and analyse the language choices a writer has made. This includes considering both the explicit and implicit meanings behind words and phrases, and why a writer might have chosen to use them. This guide will explain in more detail how to analyse language.

Overview of language analysis

To explore, comment on and analyse the language choices a writer has made, you must understand:

- What is being described or narrated (understanding the text)
- The particular choices the writer has made (subject terminology)
- The explicit and implied meanings behind these choices (denotations and connotations)
- The overall effect or meaning the writer is trying to convey

The question will ask you to use three examples of words or phrases per paragraph. It is very important that you stick to choosing words or phrases that you have something to say about, not just obvious literary techniques (such as a simile). This is because just being able to “spot” a technique a writer has used will not get you marks. Instead, you need to be able to consider what is conveyed by the use of that technique. What image is the writer trying to create with their words? Above all, you need to consider *why* the writer has made the choices they have, and keep your selection of words or phrases compact and precise (do not try to analyse whole sentences).



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Try to practise analysing words and phrases in various texts to strengthen your skills. By consistently practising this skill, you will strengthen your ability to analyse any unseen text. But do not fall into the trap of “feature spotting” – this is when a student just “spots” techniques a writer has used, such as metaphors or personification, without any consideration of why the writer has used the technique. This type of analysis will not get you a high mark.

Exploring words and phrases

Analysing language means considering the deliberate choices a writer has made: why they have included specific words or phrases in their writing, and for what purpose. In order to do this, you should consider both the denotation and the connotations of particular words:

- Denotation = the literal meaning of a word or phrase
- Connotation = the associations or implied meanings of the word or phrase

When commenting on words and phrases from the text, you should always try to consider *why* you think the writer has chosen that particular word to use in their sentences. Below are some questions which you might ask yourself when analysing the words and phrases in a text:

Denotations and connotations	Emotional impact	Characterisation	Formality and informality
How do these layers of meaning add depth to the text?	How do the words evoke emotions or feelings in the reader? Do they create joy, sadness, fear or excitement?	Do the words reveal aspects of a character's personality, background or emotions?	Do the words make the text more relatable or distant?

The following table provides you with a list of some terms and definitions to use when analysing individual words and phrases:

Term	Definition	Example
comparative adjectives	Used to compare differences between two nouns, such as "larger", "smaller", "faster", "stronger"	"The new smartphone is faster than the previous model."
superlatives	Words used to express something of the highest quality of its kind	"The explorer's journey into uncharted territory was the most courageous expedition of the century."
emotive language	Emotive language refers to words and phrases that are intentionally used to evoke strong emotional responses in the reader	"The devastating aftermath of the natural disaster left a trail of destruction, sorrow and misery."
colloquial language	Colloquial language is informal, everyday language that is used in casual conversations and familiar settings	"The exam was a doddle; I finished the problems in no time."
imperatives	Imperatives are verb forms or sentences that are used to give commands	"Close the door behind you."



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Once you are able to identify particular words and phrases within a text, you need to develop this skill further by considering why the writer has chosen to include these within their writing.

As an example, we will explore some of the words and phrases from the table above and consider the writer's intentions.



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Words and phrases	Example	Writer's intentions
emotive language	"The devastating aftermath of the natural disaster left a trail of destruction, sorrow and misery."	The writer uses emotive language to convey the immense gravity of the situation being described. The words "devastating", "destruction", "sorrow" and "misery" are used to depict the immense suffering experienced by those affected, highlighting the destructive nature of the event.

Remember the goal of analysing words and phrases is to uncover layers of meaning, understand the writer's intent and explore how language contributes to the overall impact of the text.

Language features and techniques

It is important that you are familiar with key literary terms so that it can help to *support* your analysis of the text (but should never be used in place of analysis). It is much more important that you clearly articulate the intended effects of any terms that you use.

The table below provides some definitions of key literary terms. This list is not exhaustive, but it is simply a guide to some of the techniques that might be most useful when analysing a text.

Language technique	Definition	Example
Simile	A simile is a figure of speech that directly compares two different things, using "like" or "as" to highlight their similarities	"Her smile was as radiant as the morning sun, casting its warm glow upon everyone she encountered."
Metaphor	A metaphor is a figure of speech that equates or describes one thing in terms of another, asserting that they are the same	"The stormy sea was an untamed beast, its ferocious waves crashing against the shore with unrestrained fury, devouring all in its path."
Imagery	Imagery engages the reader's senses by using vivid and detailed language to	"The sun-kissed waves crashed against the golden shore, their frothy white caps



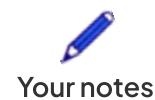
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	create mental images	glistening in the radiant morning light.”
Alliteration	Alliteration involves the repetition of consonant sounds, usually at the beginning of words or stressed syllables, within a phrase or sentence	“The swirling mist silently settled on the sleepy meadow.”
Personification	Personification attributes human characteristics or qualities to inanimate objects, animals or abstract concepts	“The weary old oak tree, its gnarled branches outstretched like weathered arms, whispered ancient wisdom to the breeze, as if carrying the weight of centuries on its bark.”
Onomatopoeia	Onomatopoeia is using words that imitate or mimic the sounds they represent	“The crackling fire whispered its secrets, its warm embrace accompanied by the gentle pop and sizzle of the logs as they surrendered to the dance of the flames.”
Repetition	Repetition involves the deliberate repetition of words, phrases, sounds or grammatical structures to create emphasis, reinforce ideas or establish rhythm	“Through the ebb and flow of life, I have learned to persist, to persist in the face of adversity, to persist in the pursuit of my dreams, to persist in the pursuit of knowledge.”
Juxtaposition	Juxtaposition places two contrasting ideas, images or concepts side by side to highlight their differences or create a striking effect	“The elegant ballroom was adorned with exquisite chandeliers and fine artwork, while the servants’ quarters below held nothing but bare walls.”

Once you are able to identify and understand different literary techniques, you need to develop this skill further by considering why the writer has chosen to include these techniques in their writing.

As an example, we will explore one of the language techniques from the table above and consider the writer’s intentions.

Language technique	Example	Writer’s intentions
Metaphor	“The stormy sea was an untamed beast, its	The writer has used a metaphor in order to convey the intense and powerful nature of the stormy sea. By describing the sea as an “untamed beast” the writer is suggesting the sea embodies the qualities of wildness,



	ferocious waves crashing against the shore with unrestrained fury, devouring all in its path."	unpredictability and also a sense of danger. This comparison helps the reader to feel the magnitude of the storm's force and the chaos it brings.
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In this example, the writer's use of a metaphor to describe the stormy sea is clearly interpreted and analysed. The response has considered why the writer may have chosen to use a metaphor and explored its intended effect on the reader.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

It is more important to explore the effects of the writer's choices than it is to use over-complicated terminology. You can be just as successful in writing about the effect of a specific word choice as you are in writing about complex language features.

Incorporating language analysis into your answer

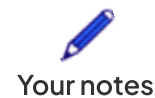
Remember, you are being tested on your ability to select appropriate words or phrases from the text to analyse. But selecting the right language to comment on is only one part of what you have got to do: you also need to be able to integrate language analysis into your answer in a clear, coherent and concise way.

A high-level response will:

- Select relevant and concise words or phrases from the text to comment on
- Incorporate these words or phrases into an explanation of meaning
- Embed those directly quoted words or phrases into your sentences, giving context to the quote

For example:

Lower level example	Analysis
<i>The writer uses a verb to show she is like an animal. This is shown by the quote "snarl". This shows that the writer is like an animal, because an animal snarls</i>	This example does not give any context for the quote; how has the word "snarl" been used? What is the context? The fact that it is a verb is irrelevant to the explanation, which just repeats the initial point. It does not explore what images are created by the use of that particular word
Higher level example	Analysis



The writer answers anyone who questions her husband's choices with a "snarl", which tells us that she is answering back fiercely. This is reminiscent of a wild animal's growl when threatened or challenged, and is an instinctive reaction, which suggests the writer is protecting her loved ones.

This example starts by placing the word "snarl" in context: where and when it is used in the text. It comments on the explicit meaning of the word, before considering the implied meaning of the writer's choice and the images it brings to mind.

So remember:

- Always give the quote you are using context:
 - In what situation has it been used?
 - What is it being used to describe?
- Consider the obvious meaning behind the word or phrase first
- Then explore the implied meaning of the word or phrase, and why the writer has chosen it

Analysis

If you think of all the questions that have come before this as an autopsy, then this Analysis question is like the **trial**. And just like a lawyer or investigator would do, you need to **look at the evidence** – in this case, your text extract – and ask three questions in order to interrogate it and get to the truth:

1. What have they done?

What have they written about? What's the **meaning** and **purpose** of the text?

2. How have they done it?

What writing techniques have they used? **Think** of your figurative language techniques.

3. Why did they do it?

What effect were they hoping to achieve? How do they want you to think and feel?

How do you respond personally to the text – was the **writer's intention** successful?



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Question 2 Language Task: Model Answer

Question 2 Language Task: Model Answer

Question 2 is split into two tasks: a short-answer task and a language analysis task. Both tasks will be based on Text C in your reading insert, and are designed to test your ability to select and interpret what you read appropriately.

The following guide will demonstrate how to answer the language task question from the June 2022 exam paper.

Text C (June 2022)

The following is Text C taken from the June 2022 exam paper. It is about a writer's experience of supporting her husband's training to compete in an extreme event, and contains both the explicit and implicit information you will need in order to answer the question.

Text C: What it's like to be married to a future Ironman

In this blog post the writer looks back on their husband's preparations to compete in an Ironman event.

I'm a little hesitant to publish this because there's a risk that I'll just be moaning and I'll come across as whiny, but it's information I wish someone had given me before we signed up for the whole Ironman thing.

My husband, Sam, started training in January for Ironman Canada at the end of July. He got himself an expert coach and monthly training plans. I felt reassured this meant he might at least survive the 3.86 km swim, a 180.25 km bicycle ride and a marathon (42.20 km) run, raced in that order.

5

His training ramped up as you'd expect. Initially, it didn't really impact our lives too much. If anything, it was a good thing. Now, we were both training for things – it felt like a real partnership as we plotted our weekends to give us time to train and time together as a family. It was fun. If we went away, we had to fit his bike ride of 1–3 hours into the weekend but that was totally do-able. We've a pool where we live which really helped – not having to drive to/from water at least saved travelling time.

10

By May he was training early and most of both weekend mornings. Being honest, I resented that. I agreed sullenly, yes, I still wanted him to do the Ironman, and no, I didn't expect him to drop out. I was just fed up with his absences.

15

June was all about Ironman. Endless weekends with Sam gone until 5pm each day. After exercise he would need to sleep for an hour or so, thus he was technically gone for longer. I was desperate for us to go away and have a break from it.



I tried to book a weekend camping but abandoned it. We would have spent the whole time fitting Sam's training around what we were doing, and it wasn't worth it. That year the kids didn't go camping at all. 20

My own freedom to run was curtailed. Saturdays became all about childcare. I only managed one Saturday trail-run with the girls from April onwards and that was thanks to wonderful friends who got up at 6.45 on a Saturday to watch my son. I got fed up with not being able to say yes to invitations. 25

We didn't do any family hiking for months. Sam justifiably didn't want to hike after exercising.

There was so much laundry ('different road conditions') so much extra food ('fuel') and so much gear (multiple pairs of goggles with different tints 'because you never know...')! Smiling understandingly, Sam assured me the next one will be cheaper. Next one? 30

'Because it's there,' I'd snarl to anyone who dared question why any sane mortal would tackle an Ironman. I enjoyed mercilessly shaming his less-than-supportive business partner into recognising the potentially boundless benefits of Sam's well-publicised adventure for their newly-established, fledgling travel company. A flurry of online articles described me as 'a runner married to a triathlete' – it took me a few moments to recognise our family and beam with immeasurable pride. 35

Our son missed having Dad around at the weekends, especially if he woke up after Sam had left to train on a Saturday when sometimes there were tears. But he got used to the different dynamic. He was given an 'Ironman' superhero toy as a birthday gift by some relatives and immediately started making it swim, bike and run! The poor child thinks that this is how normal families operate. 40

Having said all that, watching Sam emerge god-like from the water, power past us on his bike and rocket down the finishing chute, head held high as our kids cheered with the crowd – utterly incredible and intoxicating, one of life's rare pinnacles of perfection. It had been an epic journey for all of us. I'm so glad we did it. And next year? Well yes, it's my turn... 45

Question 2(d) model answer

Below is Question 2(d) from the June 2022 exam paper (you can find a breakdown of this question [here](#)):



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(d) Re-read paragraphs 10 and 12.

- Paragraph 10 begins 'Because it's there ...' and is about the writer's reactions to other people's views.
- Paragraph 12 begins 'Having said all that ...' and is about the writer's feelings at the end of the race.

Explain how the writer uses language to convey meaning and to create effect in these paragraphs. Choose **three** examples of words or phrases from **each** paragraph to support your answer. Your choices should include the use of imagery.

Write about 200 to 300 words.

Up to 15 marks are available for the content of your answer.

Based on the above question, the following model answer demonstrates an explanation of how the writer uses language to convey meaning and to create effects. It is an example of a full-mark answer (15/15).



Your notes

The response starts by focusing on the question, with no unnecessary introduction

The writer uses language in Paragraph 10 to show the writer's reactions to other people's views about her husband's choices. Firstly, the writer describes her answer as a **"snarl"** to anyone who "dared question" her husband's choices. To "snarl" is to answer back fiercely, and this is reminiscent of a wild animal's growl, and the baring of teeth when an animal is challenged or threatened. It is an instinctive reaction that suggests the writer is showing her protective instincts towards her loved ones. This sense of protectiveness continues when the writer reveals that she **"enjoyed mercilessly shaming"** her husband's business partner, who hadn't been supportive. The writer suggests that she took pleasure in making him feel bad about not showing more support, and the use of the adverb "mercilessly" implies she felt no remorse in doing so. Finally, the writer's feelings of pride towards her husband are suggested with **"beam with immeasurable pride"**, implying her wide smile, immense pleasure and satisfaction at being part of a family that contains a triathlete. The adjective "immeasurable" suggests these feelings have no end.

There are three distinct examples of language chosen to analyse – this one analyses imagery

The language analysis "zooms in" on particular words to consider why the writer has chosen them

The response is structured logically

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The response clearly separates the two paragraphs requiring analysis

Three separate examples are given, including one which focuses on imagery

In Paragraph 12, the writer uses language to show her feelings at the end of the race, sharing in the sense of power and achievement of her husband. She begins by describing watching her husband **“emerge god-like from the water”**. This is a dramatic and powerful exit, suggesting the strength of a conquering hero. The image of “god-like” implies that her husband has achieved more than a mere “mortal” and that he has been transformed into something superhuman. This imagery continues when she describes watching him **“power past us”**, which demonstrates that he was still full of strength and energy even at the end of a gruelling race. Furthermore, the metaphor **“rocket down the finishing chute”** with his “head held high” suggests his incredible speed and energy at the end, as if he was propelled by rocket fuel to a higher state of self-esteem.

Literary terminology is used accurately, appropriately and judiciously

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Unannotated model answer

Model answer:

The writer uses language in Paragraph 10 to show the writer's reactions to other people's views about her husband's choices. Firstly, the writer describes her answer as a “snarl” to anyone who “dared question” her husband's choices. To “snarl” is to answer back fiercely, and this is reminiscent of a wild animal's growl, and the baring of teeth when an animal is challenged or threatened. It is an instinctive reaction that suggests the writer is showing her protective instincts towards her loved ones. This sense of protectiveness continues when the writer reveals that she “enjoyed mercilessly shaming” her husband's business partner, who hadn't been supportive. The writer suggests that she took pleasure in making him feel bad about not showing more support, and the use of the adverb “mercilessly” implies she felt no remorse in doing so. Finally, the writer's feelings of pride towards her husband are suggested with “beam with immeasurable pride”, implying her wide smile, immense pleasure and satisfaction at being part of a family that contains a triathlete. The adjective “immeasurable” suggests these feelings have no end.



Your notes

In Paragraph 12, the writer uses language to show her feelings at the end of the race, sharing in the sense of power and achievement of her husband. She begins by describing watching her husband “emerge god-like from the water”. This is a dramatic and powerful exit, suggesting the strength of a conquering hero. The image of “god-like” implies that her husband has achieved more than a mere “mortal” and that he has been transformed into something superhuman. This imagery continues when she describes watching him “power past us”, which demonstrates that he was still full of strength and energy even at the end of a gruelling race. Furthermore, the metaphor “rocket down the finishing chute” with his “head held high” suggests his incredible speed and energy at the end, as if he was propelled by rocket fuel to a higher state of self-esteem.

Commentary:

- The response starts by focusing on the question, with no unnecessary introduction
- Three distinct examples of language are chosen to analyse for each paragraph
- The language analysis “zooms in” on particular words to consider why the writer has chosen them
- The response is structured logically
- The response includes analysis of imagery
- The response clearly separates the two paragraphs requiring analysis
- Literary terminology is used accurately, appropriately and **judiciously**

The suggested word count for this question is advisory, and you are not penalised for going either under or over 200–300 words. However, writing too much or too little can be self-penalising, so it is a good idea to use the suggested word count as a guide.

Summary

- Remember to read the question carefully and highlight:
 - The instructions (what you have to do)
 - The focus of the question (what you have to analyse in the text)
- Make sure that you are using the paragraphs indicated in the question
- Ensure you highlight three distinct examples of words or phrases to analyse:
 - Do not highlight whole sentences
 - Ensure you also include at least one use of imagery per paragraph
- When writing your answer, ensure you put the quotation from the text in context:
 - What is the quote about, or describing?

- This helps your answer make sense overall

The full June 2022 exam paper is available [here](#).



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